cross-LOC infiltrations more so than before and also directed Lashkar operatives in Indian-administered Kashmir to scale back the level of violence still further.[15] According to several Pakistani-based journalists with sources in the ISI and Lashkar, the group was told that support for the Kashmir jihad would return to previous levels and pressed the group to remain patient.[16] Instead, militancy continued to decline in the Kashmir theater and by 2006 even the Indian Defence Minister acknowledged Pakistan's contribution to the reduction in violence there.[17] Jihadi outfits exist to fight, but many Lashkar militants no longer had the opportunity to do so on the Kashmir front. Worse, this was a direct result of state pressure, to which the leadership appeared to submit. The group had agreed to government oversight in order to keep its supplies open. It had a steady flow of resources and recruits, but was under orders to limit their use in Indian-controlled Kashmir. The leadership's control over some of its members weakened as a result.

Meanwhile, attacks against Coalition forces in Afghanistan jumped to over 5,000 in 2006, more than a three-fold increase from the previous year.[18] This rapid escalation had been building since at least 2003.[19] Significant recruiting efforts directed toward Pakistani volunteers began in 2004 and these recruits were playing an important role in the Afghan insurgency by 2005.[20] Many of them were pro-Taliban Pashtuns from the Tribal Areas, but an increasing number of men from a variety of Punjab-based outfits, as well as their splinter cells, also began heading for the Afghan front. Most were from the Deobandi outfits, but militants from Lashkar were among them. Small Lashkar splinters (or spinoffs) had been active in Afghanistan since 2002 and by 2004 the leadership was beginning to pay more attention to that front. Lashkar had no hope of leading the jihad being waged there and its core leaders, who remained India-centric, still viewed liberating Kashmir as the most legitimate front on which to fight. But Lashkar was a pan-Islamist organization and there was an occupation in Afghanistan that was becoming more difficult to ignore. Further, the group was being forced to hold back more of its militants in accordance with ISI pressure to reduce activities in Indian-administered Kashmir. A small number of Lashkar operatives began appearing in Kunar and Nuristan provinces in 2004, though they kept a relatively low profile at the time.[21] As the Kashmir jihad continued to decelerate and the Afghan insurgency to